Here We Are

By Dorothy Parker

The young man in the new blue suit finished arranging the glistening luggage in tight corners of the Pullman compartment. He sat down, leaning back in the seat opposite the girl in beige. She looked as new as a peeled egg. Her hat, her fur, her frock, her gloves were glossy and stiff with novelty.

She had been staring raptly out of the window, but as the young man sat down, she turned politely from the pane, met his eyes, started a smile and got it about half done, and rested her gaze just above his right shoulder.

"Well, here we are," he said.

"Here we are," she said. "Aren't we?"

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INTRODUCTION

Anyone who has been married knows the real truth that marriage is hard work and, while it might get easier over time, marriage always takes effort. – At least that's what I've been told.

Sure, engagement is exciting and happy and planning a wedding can be fun, even thrilling at times. But the real nitty-gritty that happens once you've said your "I do's" is what people rarely talk or think about beforehand.

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"Well!" he said. "How does it feel to be an old married lady?"

"Oh, it's too soon to ask me that," she said. "At least-I mean. Well, I mean, goodness, we've only been married about three hours, haven't we?"

The young man studied his wrist-watch as if he were just acquiring the knack of reading time. "We have been married," he said, "exactly two hours and twenty-six minutes."

"My," she said. "It seems like longer. I didn't have any idea what time it was. Getting back from

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the church, and then all those people, and then changing all my clothes, and then everybody throwing things. Goodness, I don't see how people do it every day."

"Do what?" he said.

"Get married," she said. "When you think of all the people, all over the world, getting married just as if it was nothing."

"Well, let's not worry about people all over the world," he said. "We've got something better to think about."

"I know," she said. "But it's sort of such a big thing to do, it makes you feel queer. How does anybody know what's going to happen next?"

"We know darn well what's going to happen next," he said. "I mean. I mean-well,we know we're going to be happy. Don't we?"

"Oh, of course," she said. "Only . . . an awful lot of people that get married, it doesn't turn out so well. And I guess they all must have thought it was going to be great."

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"Come on, now," he said. "This is no way to start a honeymoon. Look at us-all married and the wedding all done and all."

"Ah, it was nice, wasn't it?" she said. ""Ellie and Louise looked lovely, didn't they?"

"Listen," he said. "When I was standing up there in that old church waiting for you to come up, and I saw those two bridesmaids, I thought to myself, I thought, 'Well, I never knew Louise could look like that!' Why, she'd have knocked anybody's eye out. "Boy!"

"I'm terribly glad you thought so," she said. "How did you think Ellie looked?"

"Why, I honestly didn't get a look at her," he said.

"Oh, really?" she said. "Well, I never saw anybody look as beautiful as Ellie looked today. And you didn't even notice her. But you never pay attention to Ellie, anyway. Don't think I haven't noticed it. It makes me feel just terrible. It makes me feel just awful, that you don't like my own sister."

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"I do like her!" he said. "I'm crazy for Ellie. I think she's a great kid."

"Don't think it makes any difference to Ellie!" she said. "It isn't anything to her whether you like her or not. The only thing is, it makes it awfully hard for me that you don't like her. It's going to be awfully hard for me that you won't want my own sister to come and see me. It's going to make it awfully hard for me that you won't ever want my family around. I know how you feel about my family. Don't think I haven't seen it!"

"Oh, now, come on!" he said. "What's all this talk about not wanting your family around? Why, you know how I feel about your family. I think your old lady-I think your mother's swell. And Ellie. And your father. What's all this talk?"

"Well," she said. "Lots of people get married, and they think it's going to be great, and then it all goes to pieces because people don't like people's families."

"Honey," he said, "what is all this? What are

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you getting all angry about? Hey, look, this is our honeymoon. What are you trying to start a fight for?"

"Ah, I'm sorry I was cross," she said. "Yes, don't let's ever fight. We won't be like a whole lot of them. We won't fight or be nasty or anything. Will we?"

"You bet your life we won't," he said.

"I guess I will take this darned old hat off," she said. "Do you like it, sweetheart . . .do you really like it?"

"Well, I'll tell you," he said. "I know this is the new style and everything like that, and it's probably great. Only I like the kind of a hat like that blue hat you had. Gee, I liked that hat."

"Oh, really?" she said. "Well, that's nice. The first thing you say to me, as soon as you get me off on a train away from my family and everything, is that you don't like my hat."

"Now, honey," he said, "I never said anything like that. I only said--I don't know anything about

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hats. I'll be crazy about this one as soon as I get used to it. What do I know about women's hats?"

"It's too bad," she said, "you didn't marry somebody that would get the kind of hats you'd like. Why didn't you marry Louise? You always think she looks so beautiful."

"Ah, now, honey," he said. "For heaven's sakes!"

"All you've done, ever since we got on this train, is talk about her. Here I've sat and listened to you saying how wonderful Louise is. Why didn't you ask her to marry you? I'm sure you'd have been much happier."

"Listen, baby," he said, "while you're talking about things like that, why didn't you marry Joe Brooks?"

"Well, I'm not so sure I'm not sorry I didn't," she said. "There! Joe Brooks wouldn't have waited until he got me all off alone and then sneered at my taste in clothes. Joe Brooks has always been fond of me!"

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"Yeah," he said. "He's fond of you. He was so fond of you he didn't even send a wedding present. That's how fond of you he **was.**"

"I happen to know for a fact," she said, "that he was away on business, and as soon as he comes back he's going to give me anything I want, for the apartment."

"Listen," he said. "I don't want anything he gives you in our apartment. Anything he gives you, I'll throw right out the window. That's what I think of your friend Joe Brooks. And how do you know where he is and what he's going to do, anyway? Has he been writing to you?"

"I suppose my friends can correspond with me," she said. "I didn't hear there was any law against that."

"Well, I suppose they can't!" he said. "And what do you think of that? I'm not going to have my wife getting a lot of letters from cheap traveling salesmen!"

"Joe Brooks is not a cheap traveling

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salesman!" she said. "You've got a lot of right to talk about Joe Brooks," she said. "You and your friend Louise. All you ever talk about is Louise."

"Oh, for heaven's sakes!" he said. "What do I care about Louise? I just thought she was a friend of yours, that's all. That's why I ever even noticed her."

"Well, you certainly took an awful lot of notice of her today," she said. "On our wedding day! You said yourself when you were standing there in the church you just kept thinking of her. Right up at the altar. Oh, right in the presence of God! And all you thought about was Louise."

"Listen, honey," he said, "I never should have said that. I was just telling you that because it was so kind of crazy. I thought it would make you laugh."

"Well, it didn't," she said.

"No, I know it didn't," he said. "It certainly did not. Ah, baby, and we ought to be laughing, too. Hell, honey lamb, this is our honeymoon. What's the matter?"

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"I don't know," she said. "We used to squabble a lot when we were going together and then engaged and everything, but I thought everything would be so different as soon as you were married."

"Well, we haven't got much longer to wait now," he said. "I mean-well, we'll be in New York in about twenty minutes. Then we can have dinner, and sort of see what we feel like doing. Would you like to go to a show or something?"

"Why, whatever you like," she said. "I sort of didn't think people went to theaters and things on their-I mean, I've got a couple of letters I simply must write. Don't let me forget."

"Oh," he said. "You're going to write letters tonight? I thought when we got in, we could go right up to the Biltmore and maybe have a little dinner in the room, kind of quiet, and then do whatever we wanted. I mean. I mean-well, let's go right up there from the station."

"Oh, yes, let's," she said. "I'm so glad we're going to the Biltmore. I just love it. I always sleep so

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well there. I go right off to sleep the minute I put my head on the pillow."

"Oh, you do?" he said. He rose, balanced a moment, crossed over and sat down beside her.

"Do you really have to write those letters tonight?" he said.

"Well," she said, "I don't suppose they'd get there any quicker than if I wrote them tomorrow."

There was a silence with things going on in it. "And we won't ever fight any more, will we?" he said.

"Oh, no," she said. "Not ever! I don't know what made me like that. We won't go all to pieces," she said. "We won't fight. It'll all be different, now we're married. It'll all be lovely. Reach me down my hat, will you, sweetheart? It's time I was putting it on. Thanks. Ah, I'm so sorry you don't like it."

"I do so like it!" he said.

"You said you didn't," she said. "You said you thought it was perfectly terrible."

"I never said any such thing," he said. "You're crazy."

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"All right, I may be crazy," she said. "Thank you very much. But that's what you said. Not that it matters-it's just a little thing. But it makes you feel pretty funny to think you've gone and married somebody that says you have perfectly terrible taste in hats. And then goes and says you're crazy, beside."

"Honey," he said. "Stop it, will you? What do you want to start all this for? I love the damned hat. I mean, I love your hat. I love anything you wear. What more do you want me to say?"

"Well, I don't want you to say it like that," she said.

"Ah, baby. Baby lamb," he said. "For heaven's sakes. Look at us-we're on our honeymoon. Here we are married! Here we are!"

"Yes, here we are," she said. "Aren't we?"

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